

3. Gupta Administration & Economy

Level	In charge of
Bhukti (province)	Uparika
Vishaya (district)	Vishayapati
Vithi	Nagarpati
Village	Gramika

Officer	Role
Kumaramatyā	Provincial officer
Mahādanda Nayaka	Officer of justice/punishment
Sandhivigrahika	Officer of war and peace
Nagar Shreshthi	Chief banker

Tax/term	Meaning
Bhaga	1/6th of produce, paid by cultivators
Bhoga	Periodic supplies of fruit/flowers to the king
Bali	Oppressive/forced tax (originally voluntary)
Uparikara	Extra tax
Vishti	Forced labour
Senabhakti	Obligation on villages to feed the army when it passed through
Kulyavapa & Dronavapa	Terms denoting units of land measurement in Gupta-era inscriptions — a direct PYQ association, not to be confused with coin denominations

Gupta administration was **decentralised**, similar in concept to the later Chola pattern discussed further below.

4. Gupta Architecture

Site	Detail
Bhitargaon Temple	Kanpur, UP; oldest surviving brick temple in India; dedicated to Krishna
Dashavatara Temple	Lalitpur (Jhansi), UP
Udayagiri Caves	Vidisha, MP; Varaha (boar) avatar of Vishnu, protecting Goddess Earth; built under Chandragupta II
Bagh Caves	Madhya Pradesh

5. Post-Gupta — Vakatakas & Pushyabhuti/Vardhana Dynasty

Dynasty	Fact
Vakataka	Founder Vindhyashakti; feudatories of the Satavahanas; matrimonial ally of the Guptas via Prabhavati Gupta–Rudrasena II marriage; capital Pravarapura
Pushyabhuti/Vardhana	Founder Pushyabhuti; capital Thanesar, Haryana

Vardhana genealogy event	Detail
Prabhakarvardhan	Son of Pushyabhuti; had two sons (Rajyavardhan, Harshavardhan) and a daughter (Rajshree)
Rajshree's marriage	Married Grihavarman of the Maukhari dynasty; Grihavarman was killed by Shashank (Gauda king of North Bengal), who had allied with Devagupta of Malwa
Rajyavardhan	Avenged Grihavarman's death but was himself killed by Shashank
Harshavardhana	Youngest son; defeated Shashank; began his reign in 606 AD

6. Harshavardhana (606–647 AD)

Fact	Detail
Capital	Kannauj (Kanyakubja) — adopted after the Maukhari line ended
Defeated	Dhruvasena II, ruler of Vallabhi, Gujarat
Defeated by	Pulakeshin II (Chalukya king), on the banks of the Narmada
Traveller	Chinese pilgrim Hiuen-Tsang (Xuanzang) visited for c. 14 years

Assemblies	Held at Kannauj (to honour Hiuen-Tsang) and at Prayag (every 5 years, at the Ganga-Yamuna-Saraswati confluence — the traditional origin of the Kumbh Mela)
Religion	A Shaivite by personal faith; strongly patronised Buddhism
Author	Wrote 3 plays — Ratnavali, Nagananda, Priyadarshika
Biography	<i>Harshacharita</i> , by his court poet Banabhatta (who also wrote Kadambari)
Chalukyan title for Harsha	"Sakalottarapathanatha" ("Lord of all of North India") — per a Chalukyan inscription
Succession	No son; married his daughter into the Maitraka dynasty (capital Vallabhi, Gujarat) — his dynasty ended after him

7. South India — Sangam Age

Concept	Detail
Megalithic Age	South India's Iron Age (c. 2500 BC–500 BC); no separate Bronze Age; Black-and-Red Ware pottery; found around graves
Thinais (5 ecological/social regions)	Kurinji (hunting-gathering), Palai (cattle-lifting/plundering), Mullai (animal husbandry), Marutam (agriculture), Neytal (fishing/salt collection); each had a chief called Muvendar
Sangams	3 assemblies of poets, patronised by the Pandyas: 1st at Madurai (Agastya) — literature lost; 2nd at Kapadapuram (Tolkappiyar, author of the earliest Tamil grammar text <i>Tolkappiyam</i>); 3rd at Madurai (Nakkirar)
Sangam literature forms	Melkannakku (narrative, 8 major works) and Kilkannakku (didactic, 18 minor works); themes: Akam (love) and Puram (war)
Silapathikaram	By Ilango Adigal; love-triangle story of Kovalan, wife Kannagi, and courtesan Madhavi; Kannagi worshipped as goddess of chastity/purity, especially in Kerala
Manimegalai	By Sattanar; story of the daughter of Kovalan and Madhavi

The Ashokan inscriptions refer to the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas as "Keralaputras" and describe them as among the most powerful contemporary neighbours.

Early (Sangam-Age) Chera, Chola, Pandya

Dynasty	Capital	Emblem	Port	Notable ruler
Chera	Vanji/Vanchi	Bow and Arrow	Muziris/Muchiris, Tondi	Senguttuvan ("Red Chera") — greatest Chera; connections with Rome (Augustus Temple built by Romans)
Chola (early)	Uraiyur; alternate port capital Puhar/Kaveripattinam	Tiger	Kaveripattinam	Karikala (also called Karikal) — greatest early Chola, fought the Battle of Venni; also mentioned in Sangam literature alongside Kochenganan; territory lay between the Pennar and Kaveri rivers
Pandya	Madurai, on the Vaigai river	Fish	Korkai	First mentioned by Megasthenes as famous for pearl trading; traded with the Roman Empire

SOCIETY

Ruling class = Arasar; rich landlords = Vellalar/Vella; landless labourers/slaves = Kadaiyiar (Adima). The three chiefs (Chera-Chola-Pandya) collectively called **Muvendar**.

8. Chalukyas — Three Branches

Branch	Capital	Note
Chalukyas of Badami (earliest)	Vatapi	Founder Jayasimha (or Pulakeshin I as alternate founder-figure); originally feudatories of the Kadambas of Banavasi
Eastern Chalukyas	Vengi	Founded by Kubja Vishnuvardhan, brother of Pulakeshin II
Western/Later Chalukyas	Kalyani	Rose after defeating the Rashtrakutas

Ruler	Detail
Pulakeshin I	543–566 AD; important early ruler; sons Kirtivarman and Mangalesh
Pulakeshin II	610–642 AD; greatest Chalukya ruler; killed his uncle Mangalesh to take the throne; defeated Harshavardhana on the Narmada; defeated Pallava ruler Mahendravarman I ; took the title Dakshinapatheshwar ("Lord of the South"); visited by Hiuen-Tsang; described in the Aihole Pillar Inscription , composed by court poet Ravikirti (found at the Meguti Jain temple, Aihole, Karnataka); eventually defeated and killed by Mahendravarman's son, Narasimhavarman I , who took the title Vatapikonda ("conqueror of Vatapi")
Vikramaditya I → Kirtivarman II	Later rulers; Kirtivarman II (great-grandson of Vikramaditya I) was defeated by the Rashtrakutas, ending the Badami line

Chalukyan (Vesara) Temple Architecture

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Term	Detail
Vesara style	A mix of Nagara (North Indian) and Dravida (South Indian) styles, developed by the Chalukyas
Aihole group	Durga Temple (apsidal plan), Ladkhan Temple, Ravana Phadi caves, Huchimalligudi Temple — all in Karnataka
Pattadakal group	UNESCO World Heritage Site (1987); 10 temples total (4 Nagara-style, 6 Dravida-style); Virupaksha Temple (built by Queen Lokmahadevi to commemorate her husband Vikramaditya II's victory) and Galaganath, Papanatha, Sangameshwar temples

9. Pallavas (c. 275-897 AD)

Fact	Detail
Founder	Sinha Vishnu
Capital	Kanchipuram
Greatest ruler	Narasimhavarman I (630-668 AD), son of Mahendravarman I; defeated Pulakeshin II, took the title Vatapikonda; his war with the Chalukyas is also called the Battle of Vatapi; also carried the title "Mamalla"
Mahendravarman I	Defeated by Pulakeshin II at the Battle of Pullalur
Architecture	Developed the Dravida style of temple architecture; founded the port city of Mahabalipuram ; built the Pancha Rathas (Seven/Five Rathas) and the Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram; Kailasanathar Temple at Kanchipuram, built by Narasimhavarman II; also the "Descent of the Ganges"/Arjuna's Penance rock-cut relief

10. Rashtrakutas (753-982 AD)

Fact	Detail
Founder	Dantidurga — first and most important Rashtrakuta king; defeated the Chalukyas of Badami (specifically Kirtivarman II) to found the dynasty in 753 AD ; earlier the Rashtrakutas had been feudatories/vassals of the Badami Chalukyas; performed the Hiranyagarbha ceremony
Capital	Manyakheta
Krishna I	Son of Dantidurga; built the monolithic Kailasa/Kailasanath Temple at Ellora , carved from a single rock (Aurangzeb reportedly tried and failed to damage it)
Amoghavarsha (814-878 AD)	Capital Manyakheta; converted to Jainism; his court is associated with celebrated Kannada poets Pampa, Ponna and Ranna
Later rulers	Govinda II, Govinda III (defeated Gurjara-Pratihara ruler Nagabhatta II), Indra III (defeated Gurjara-Pratihara ruler Mahipal)

DIRECT PYQ / TRIPARTITE STRUGGLE

The **Tripartite Struggle** (8th-10th century AD) for control of Kannauj was fought between the **Rashtrakutas, Gurjara- Pratiharas and Palas**. Also directly asked: "The Kailasa temple at Ellora was built under the patronage of ___" → **Rashtrakuta king Krishna I**.

11. Pala & Gurjara-Pratihara — Quick Cross-Reference

Dynasty	Founder	Notable ruler/fact
Pala	Gopala	Founded Odantapuri University; son Dharmapala founded Vikramshila University and adopted Mahayana Buddhism; Beetapala and Dhiman — celebrated artists of the Pala Age
Gurjara-Pratihara	Nagabhatta I	Greatest ruler: Mihir Bhoj

12. Ajanta & Ellora Caves

Site	Detail
Ajanta	Maharashtra; 29 caves (Chaityas + Viharas); built by the Vakatakas; entirely Buddhist; famous for fresco paintings; UNESCO World Heritage Site (1983)
Ellora	Maharashtra; 34 caves — Hindu, Buddhist AND Jain; construction spans the Satavahana and Rashtrakuta periods; Kailasa Temple (cave 16) built by Krishna I; UNESCO World Heritage Site (1983)

13. Hoysalas

Fact	Detail
Capital	Halebidu, also known as Dwara Samudram
Founder	Nripakama II
Architecture	Distinctive star-shaped temples; Chennakeshava Temple (Vishnu) and Hoysaleshwar Temple (Shiva) — both UNESCO World Heritage

14. Imperial Cholas (c. 850–1279 AD)

Ruler	Reign/detail
Vijayalaya	Founder, c. 850 AD; originally a feudatory of the Pallavas; defeated the Mutharaiyar (a Pallava-aligned local power) to capture Thanjavur; took the title " Narkesari "
Aditya I	Son of Vijayalaya; expanded by occupying Pallava territory
Parantaka I	Defeated by Rashtrakuta king Krishna III at the Battle of Vellai/Takkolam ; also himself earlier defeated Pallava ruler Rajasimha II at the Battle of Vellore
Rajaraja I	985–1014 AD; began conquest of Sri Lanka and the Maldives; defeated the Cheras and Pandyas; built the great Brihadeeswarar Temple at Thanjavur
Rajendra I	1014–1044 AD; defeated Pala ruler Mahipal; took the title Gangaikonda Chola ("Chola who conquered the Ganga [region]"); founded the city of Gangaikonda Cholapuram , building a second Brihadeeswarar-type temple there; completed conquest of Sri Lanka; defeated the Shailendra dynasty of Sri Vijaya (Malay Peninsula/Indonesia); called the " Napoleon of South India "; contemporary of Mahmud of Ghazni

ELARA — EARLIER CHOLA-CEYLON LINK
A Chola prince named **Elara** is traditionally recorded (Sri Lankan chronicles) as having conquered and ruled part of Ceylon around the 2nd century BC — centuries before Rajendra I's much later, more complete Chola conquest of the island. Do not confuse the two events.

Administration term	Meaning
Mandalam	Province
Valnadu	Division of a Mandalam (like a district)
Nadu	Group of villages
Ur	Assembly of common people/villagers
Sabha	Assembly of learned Brahmins
Uttaramerur Inscription	Chingleput district, Tamil Nadu; describes local self-government/village committee elections by lottery ("Kudavolai" system) — voters needed to own property
Variyam	Committees handling specific local functions (e.g. Eri/Tank Variyam for irrigation/tank maintenance)
Land grant types	Devadan (to temples), Brahmadeya (to Brahmins), Shalabhoga (to schools), Pallichchandam (to Jain monks)
Taxes	Vetti (forced labour); Kadamai (land revenue)

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE
Brihadeeswarar Temple, Thanjavur (Rajaraja I) and the Brihadeeswarar-style temple at Gangaikonda Cholapuram (Rajendra I) — both Dravida-style; the capstone at Thanjavur weighs c. 90 tonnes; Nandi statues are placed outside the main shrine in Dravida-style temples (unlike Nagara style, where Nandi is inside); Gopuram (tall gateway tower) is a distinctive Dravida feature not found in Nagara style.

15. Temple Architecture — Nagara vs Dravida vs Vesara

Feature	Nagara (North India)	Dravida (South India)
Main shrine tower	Shikhara	Vimana
Gateway	Absent	Gopuram (tall gateway)
Nandi placement	Inside the temple	Outside the temple
Layout style	—	Often Panchayatana style (main shrine + 4 subsidiary shrines)
Common features	Garbhagriha (sanctum), Mandapa (pillared hall), Pradakshina Path (circumambulatory path)	

VESARA
A hybrid of Nagara + Dravida, developed by the Chalukyas (seen at Aihole and Pattadakal).

16. Master Revision — Learn These First

Trigger	Answer
Founder of Gupta dynasty	Sri Gupta (Chandragupta I started the Gupta Era & gold coinage)
Gupta Era started	320 AD, by Chandragupta I
Greatest Gupta ruler; called "Napoleon of India"	Samudragupta (title by V. A. Smith)
Samudragupta's inscription/poet	Prayag Prashasti; Harisena
Samudragupta's coin title	"Restorer of the Ashwamedha"

First Gupta ruler to issue silver coins	Chandragupta II (after defeating Saka Satraps)
Chandragupta II's alternate names	Vikramaditya, Devagupta, Devasri, Devaraja
Founder of Nalanda University	Kumaragupta I
Successfully resisted the Hunas	Skandagupta
Iron Pillar of Mehrauli attributed to	Chandragupta II
Kulyavapa/Dronavapa meaning	Units of land measurement
Who founded the Vardhana/Pushyabhuti dynasty	Pushyabhuti, capital Thanesar
Harshavardhana's capital	Kannauj
Harsha defeated by	Pulakeshin II, on the Narmada
Harsha's biography & author	Harshacharita, by Banabhatta
Chinese traveller during Harsha's reign	Hiuen-Tsang (Xuanzang)
3 Sangams patronised by	Pandyas
Earliest Tamil grammar text	Tolkappiyam, by Tolkappiyar
Greatest early/Sangam Chola ruler	Karikala
Greatest Chera ruler	Senguttuvan ("Red Chera")
Greatest Chalukya ruler	Pulakeshin II — defeated Harsha; title Dakshinapatheshwar
Aihole Pillar Inscription — poet	Ravikirti
Who defeated Pulakeshin II	Narasimhavarman I (Pallava); title Vatapikonda
Pallava capital & greatest ruler	Kanchipuram; Narasimhavarman I
Founder of Mahabalipuram	Narasimhavarman I
Founder of Rashtrakuta dynasty	Dantidurga, 753 AD; defeated Chalukyas of Badami
Builder of Kailasa Temple, Ellora	Krishna I (Rashtrakuta)
Kannada poets at Amoghavarsha's court	Pampa, Ponna, Ranna
Tripartite Struggle — for what, between whom	Kannauj; Rashtrakutas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, Palas
Founder of Imperial Chola dynasty	Vijayalaya, c. 850 AD; title Narkesari
Chola emblem	Tiger
Builder of Brihadeeswarar Temple, Thanjavur	Rajaraja I (985–1014 AD)
Founder of Gangaikonda Cholapuram	Rajendra I; called "Napoleon of South India"
Uttaramerur Inscription — about	Village self-government / Kudavolai lottery elections
Star-shaped temples	Hoysalas, Halebidu (Dwara Samudram)
Nagara vs Dravida main tower name	Shikhara (Nagara) / Vimana (Dravida)
Vesara style developed by	Chalukyas

17. PYQ-Style Question Bank

- Q1.** Who founded the Gupta dynasty? **Ans:** Sri Gupta.
- Q2.** Who started the Gupta Era, and when? **Ans:** Chandragupta I, 320 AD.
- Q3.** Who was called the "Napoleon of India," and by whom? **Ans:** Samudragupta; by V. A. Smith.
- Q4.** Who composed the Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription)? **Ans:** Harisena.
- Q5.** Which Gupta king first issued silver coins, and why? **Ans:** Chandragupta II, after defeating the Saka Satraps of Ujjain.
- Q6.** By what other names is Chandragupta II known? **Ans:** Vikramaditya, Devagupta, Devasri, Devaraja.
- Q7.** Who founded Nalanda University? **Ans:** Kumaragupta I.
- Q8.** Who successfully resisted the Huna invasions? **Ans:** Skandagupta.
- Q9.** To whose reign is the rust-free Iron Pillar of Mehrauli attributed? **Ans:** Chandragupta II.
- Q10.** What do the terms Kulyavapa and Dronavapa denote? **Ans:** Units of land measurement.
- Q11.** Where was Harshavardhana's capital? **Ans:** Kannauj.
- Q12.** Who defeated Harshavardhana, and where? **Ans:** Pulakeshin II, on the banks of the Narmada.
- Q13.** Who wrote the Harshacharita? **Ans:** Banabhatta.
- Q14.** Which Chinese traveller visited during Harsha's reign? **Ans:** Hiuen-Tsang (Xuanzang).
- Q15.** Who patronised the three Sangams? **Ans:** The Pandyas.
- Q16.** Who authored the Tolkappiyam? **Ans:** Tolkappiyar.
- Q17.** Who was the greatest Sangam-age Chola ruler? **Ans:** Karikala.
- Q18.** Who was the greatest Chalukya ruler, and whom did he defeat? **Ans:** Pulakeshin II; defeated Harshavardhana and Mahendravarman I.

- Q19.** Who composed the Aihole Pillar Inscription? **Ans:** Ravikirti.
- Q20.** Who defeated Pulakeshin II, and what title did he take? **Ans:** Narasimhavarman I; title Vatapikonda.
- Q21.** Who founded the port city of Mahabalipuram? **Ans:** Narasimhavarman I.
- Q22.** Who founded the Rashtrakuta dynasty, and in which year? **Ans:** Dantidurga, 753 AD.
- Q23.** Who built the Kailasa Temple at Ellora? **Ans:** Krishna I (Rashtrakuta).
- Q24.** Name the three Kannada poets at Amoghavarsha's Rashtrakuta court. **Ans:** Pampa, Ponna, Ranna.
- Q25.** The Tripartite Struggle was fought over which city, between which powers? **Ans:** Kannauj; Rashtrakutas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, Palas.
- Q26.** Who founded the Imperial Chola dynasty? **Ans:** Vijayalaya, c. 850 AD.
- Q27.** What is the Chola dynastic emblem? **Ans:** Tiger.
- Q28.** Who built the Brihadeeswarar Temple at Thanjavur? **Ans:** Rajaraja I.
- Q29.** Who founded Gangaikonda Cholapuram, and what title did he earn? **Ans:** Rajendra I; "Napoleon of South India."
- Q30.** What does the Uttaramerur Inscription describe? **Ans:** Village self-government via lottery-based (Kudavolai) elections.
- Q31.** Which dynasty built star-shaped temples, and where? **Ans:** Hoysalas, at Halebidu (Dwara Samudram).
- Q32.** What is the main-shrine tower called in Nagara style vs Dravida style? **Ans:** Shikhara (Nagara); Vimana (Dravida).
- Q33.** Which dynasty developed the Vesara style of temple architecture? **Ans:** The Chalukyas.

18. Last-Minute One-Page Revision — Entire Series Recap

PART 7 IN ONE FLOW
GUPTA EMPIRE (Sri Gupta founds → Chandragupta I starts era/gold coins → Samudragupta "Napoleon of India" → Chandragupta II Vikramaditya, silver coins, Navratnas → Kumaragupta I Nalanda → Skandagupta resists Hunas) → POST-GUPTA (Vakatakas; Pushyabhuti/Vardhana → Harsha, defeated by Pulakeshin II) → SOUTH INDIA (Sangam Age: Chera-Chola-Pandya → Chalukyas of Badami: Pulakeshin II, Vesara style → Pallavas: Narasimhavarman I, Dravida style, Mahabalipuram → Rashtrakutas: Dantidurga, Kailasa Temple → Imperial Cholas: Rajaraja I & Rajendra I, Brihadeeswarar temples, Uttaramerur local self-government).

FULL 7-PART SERIES COMPLETE
Part 1: Prehistory → Part 2: Harappan Civilization → Part 3: Vedic Age → Part 4: Mahajanapadas & Magadha → Part 5: Jainism & Buddhism → Part 6: Mauryan & Post-Mauryan → Part 7: Gupta, Harsha & South India. This closes the full Ancient History syllabus for SSC CGL/CHSL/CPO/MTS.